

THE BEAR  
"PRESS"

Written by

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Address  
Phone Number

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN

Carmy preps for dinner service in the kitchen. He's focused; the only thing he can see is the food he's preparing in front of him.

His RIGHT HAND starts to TREMBLE, but he pushes through.

CHOP. CHOP. CHOP. **FLASH.**

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - DINING AREA

Suddenly, Carmy's serving a dish table-side. Again, all he can see is the food in front of him. Everything seems normal until he places the dishes in front of his customers and when we see that they're are ALL BEARS.

He stutters when he notices, but shrugs it off. He goes back into the kitchen quickly to ask what's going on.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

The doors fly open and Carmy starts to talk, but the room is EMPTY.

He's befuddled, but not long before orders come flying in, and suddenly he's BACK TO COOKING on his own.

Now he's racing against the CLOCK--

TICKING, COUNTING DOWN, PRESSING HIM--

But he can't keep up. He's getting messy, slipping up, FALTERING.

His HAND is SHAKING UNCONTROLLABLY.

The CLOCK moves FASTER.

One of the "customers" BARGES into the kitchen. It SNARLS and SWIPES items off the counters, slowly APPROACHING.

Carmy tries to focus on the food, but the bear PUSHES him away from his station and BACKS him into the walk-in fridge.

INT. THE BEAR/FRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The door shuts like a cage, and Carmy turns around to find a bear trapped inside with him.

For a moment he's frozen. Face to face with the creature.

There's RINGING in the distance.

Time's up.

And it POUNCES.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. CARMY'S ROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy wakes up groggy, disoriented. He rubs his eyes and sits up to get a hold of himself.

He looks down at his hand - SHAKY.

He tries to GRAB IT, as if to MUFFLE IT, but it won't stop.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - MORNING

The crew trickles in one by one for the start of the day. Each person has less energy than the last. Everyone but Carmy, Richie, and Natalie is on the scene.

Sydney leads the pack, more disciplined than the rest, and heads for her locker where she exchanges her coat and backpack for her apron.

She notices the general slump everyone's in.

SYDNEY  
Morning everyone.

EVERYONE  
Morning chef.

SYDNEY  
Anyone know where Carmy or Natalie is?

Right on cue, Natalie walks in late.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)  
Nevermind.

NATALIE  
Sorry, me and Pete just had a thing.

SYDNEY  
Good thing or bad thing?

NATALIE  
Pete thing.

Sydney raises her eyebrows, sarcastic, but understanding.

SYDNEY  
I see.

NATALIE  
Where's Carmy?

SYDNEY  
I was going to ask you the same thing.

NATALIE  
Try his phone?

Sydney sighs reluctantly, but pulls out her phone anyway.

Natalie gives a reassuring smile, and heads off to her office.

Sydney dials Carmy.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/BEDROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy's phone lights up with the time. He sees the time for the first.

CARMY  
Shit.

He answers.

CARMY (CONT'D)  
(on the phone)  
Yeah?

SYDNEY  
Good morning to you too. Are you planning on joining us today any time soon?

CARMY  
Uhh, can't- not feeling well. PTO.

SYDNEY  
PTO?

CARMY  
Just ask Natalie. Sorry.

He hangs up abruptly.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Sydney looks shocked at her phone. She gives a face that says "This Bitch".

She puts her phone away, frustrated, and at the same time --

Richie walks in with more energy than everyone else combined.

RICHIE

WOO! We got a great day ahead of us!

SYDNEY

Why are we yelling already?

RICHIE

This is it! This is the big time! Major leagues! Super-Bowl! The Fucking World Cup!!!

Natalie walks out to all the noise.

NATALIE

It is barely 8 in the morning, and I can understand my literal baby better than you, what are you saying?

RICHIE

I just made your today, because I got a critic for us.

Sydney's face turns to dread.

RICHIE (CONT'D)

You're welcome.

SYDNEY

No, we can't today.

RICHIE

Yes, today.

SYDNEY

Cancel it, we're short-staffed.

Richie takes a dramatic look around.

RICHIE

All I see is the face of this  
restaurant  
(he gestures to himself)  
And a kitchen full of cooks.

SYDNEY

Carry's not coming in - ergo we  
can't have a *critic* coming in.

RICHIE

No, you know what? He's one guy,  
and we pulled off opening night,  
just fine without him.

SYDNEY

That one guy is the head chef of  
the kitchen, owner of the  
restaurant, and best fucking cook  
in Chicago.

RICHIE

I thought you wanted a chance to  
prove you can do something great.  
Well, here you go. The critic's  
coming today, and you better be  
ready.

NATALIE

Rich, lay off.

Richie walks off leaving Sydney to make a choice.

Natalie gives her a look, and she tries to avoid it.

Sydney takes a moment, and closes her eyes to accept what's  
ahead, then she gets an idea.

She grabs a nearby knife, and walks over to Richie.

RICHIE

Woah, woah! We are not doing this  
again!

Richie backs up, cautious, but she just hands it to him.

SYDNEY

Fine. You win, but you're going to  
help with prep.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/BEDROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy makes his way out of bed, and stumbles into his apartment.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Something like GREEN DAY'S "BRAIN STEW" plays over a small montage of Carmy cooking himself the crappiest breakfast you've ever seen.

Carmy BREAKS EGGS, shoves BREAD into a TOASTER, chops up a couple HOT DOGS, POURS EGG YOLK INTO A PAN.

CRACK! Egg shells SHATTER into the mix.

CARMY  
Shit. Fuck.

Carmy tries to fish the pieces out, but he STRUGGLES with his hand UNSTABLE.

He finishes the dish by FRYING EGGS, and he grabs BURNED TOAST to plate.

The music carries into --

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Ebraheim DICES TOMATOES and ONIONS, Tina FILETS FRESH SALMON, Marcus pours MILK into a BOWL and sets a TRAY OF PASTRIES into an oven.

Sydney walks around TASTING various cooks' ingredients as they all work at their own stations. Sweeps TIES HIS SHOES, Fak FIXES HIS HAIR. Richie CLEANS HIS SUIT using a lint roller.

Back to --

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy munches on a mess of food over a plastic plate while sitting on his couch.

His eyes glossed over, lost in his own thought.

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA - LUNCH TIME

Sweeps checks on a nearby table enjoying their meal.

SWEEPS  
How's everything going guys?

They throw two thumbs up, their mouths too stuffed to speak.

SWEEPS (CONT'D)  
Happy to hear it. I'll be around if  
you need anything.

He smiles and turns away to check on the kitchen.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Tina mans a station where a PAN LIGHTS FIRE. She shakes it out, turns the heat down.

EBRAHEIM  
You're making it feel like a  
microwave in here.

TINA  
How would you fit in a microwave?

EBRAHEIM  
That's not the point. It feels like  
you're trying to cook us in here.

SYDNEY (O.S.)  
Let's keep the heat down.

TINA  
Heard, chef!

EBRAHEIM  
Exactly.

Tina gives him a side eye.

Sweeps walks in and heads to Sydney.

SWEEPS  
Customers are doing good out there.  
How's the lunch rush in here?

SYDNEY  
It's a little --

Marcus runs past them holding another tray of pastries.

MARCUS  
BEHIND!

SYDNEY

Hectic. But I think I got it under control.

SWEEPS

Anything else I can do to help?

SYDNEY

Not right now. You're doing great balancing out Richie.

SWEEPS

(chuckles)

I do my best.

Richie joins in.

RICHIE

What'd I miss?

SYDNEY

(sarcastic)

Nothing, we were debating who's taller.

RICHIE

Me.

SYDNEY

I don't know. It's 2 to 1 over here.

SWEEPS

When's that critic gonna arrive?

RICHIE

He's coming in right now.

SYDNEY

Right now right now?

RICHIE

I'm opening the door for him any minute.

SYDNEY

No, let Natalie --

RICHIE

Relax. I got this. You do your thing, and I'll do mine.

Richie gives her an expecting look, then heads off.

SWEEPS

You sure you don't need anything?

SYDNEY

Nope. I got this.

Sydney puts what she's doing down, and turns to address the kitchen.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)

Listen up, everyone! I was just informed that our critic will be seated any minute. Let's give them our best shift, yes?

EVERYONE

Yes, chef!

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN

Fak looks around, surveying if any customers need help.

A man wearing a trench coat, with a hat and a pair of glasses walks in. Fak instantly spots him, and looks around for someone to greet him, but no one is there.

FAK

(to himself)

Oh my god, he's here. And it's just me.

Fak slowly walks up to the front.

FAK (CONT'D)

Good afternoon, my good sir! We've been eagerly expecting your presence. Please come this way.

He leads the man to a table. Meanwhile, Richie walks out of the kitchen, and up to the front as another guest walks in.

JASON PLUMLEE (young, tall, muscles, style - whole package) is greeted by Richie like a friend.

RICHIE

Good to see you Jason, let me show to your table.

Richie leads, and Jason follows.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Sydney stands at the front, and starts rifling off orders.

SYDNEY  
TWO STEAK, TWO CHICKEN, ONE GARLIC  
BREAD APP!

EVERYONE  
HEARD!

Everyone is in the zone as the kitchen moves slowly, and Sydney works to keep herself in a flow state.

Tina gets close to her, and starts whispering.

TINA  
You see who just came in?

SYDNEY  
No. Why?

TINA  
Take a look.

Sydney takes a quick glance behind her, but doesn't give it much thought.

TINA (CONT'D)  
He's cute, right?

SYDNEY  
What? I guess, he's fine. What does it matter Tina, I'm trying to get this right for the critic.

TINA  
That *is* the critic.

SYDNEY  
*That's* the critic?

Tina raises her eyebrows like, "YUP".

TINA  
You're blushing a little, admit it.

SYDNEY  
I'll admit it if you go fire me  
three new steaks.

Tina smiles, accomplished, and walks away.

Sydney takes one more look outside, and gets back to work.

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA

Sweeps spots Richie with the critic as he's sitting down.

He makes a SMALL NOISE to get Richie's attention; Richie turns to see him.

Sweeps makes a face asking, "you good?", and Richie makes a face in response like, "C'mon, I got this".

Sweeps can't help an eyeroll, then continues with his shift.

Richie turns back to Jason who's now reading the menu.

RICHIE

So what do you think?

JASON

This place used to be a sandwich shop, huh?

RICHIE

Not exactly, I mean --

JASON

I just wasn't expecting something like this down here.

Richie's eye twitches at the comment, unsure of it's meaning.

RICHIE

How about for food?

JASON

I like the sound of the New York Strip, what do you guys do with your potato puree' on the side?

RICHIE

And you're from New York right?  
(off Jason's nod)  
Then I think you gotta order the Oysters Rockefeller. Fresh from the Chicago River!

Richie tries for a laugh, but Jason just smiles.

CUT TO:

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN

Richie, in his own head, almost walks into Natalie.

NATALIE

Whoa, you okay there?

RICHIE

Sorry, sorry.

NATALIE

What's going on, isn't the critic here?

RICHIE

Yeah, he's here, but he's not from here. I don't get him, I talk about the streets, he's never been. I talk about the river, he doesn't swim. I talk about the Cubs, and he's a Mets fan - who THE FUCK supports the Mets? THE METS?!

NATALIE

Why don't we cool it? I can just ask Sweeps to cover you.

RICHIE

Absolutely not, I need to crack this guy.

NATALIE

He's not a pistachio, would you just lay off, we want a good review and you're not the guy right now.

RICHIE

I'm Ben Zobrist in the World Series. This is coming home.

NATALIE

Rich!

Richie ignores her and goes back out there with plates of food in hand.

Natalie looks down at her phone, expecting something, but is disappointed. She sends a quick text, and puts her phone away.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy handles a stress ball on his couch.

SQUEEZE. RELEASE. SQUEEZE. RELEASE.

His hand feels still, and lets go of the ball - it falls away.

He looks at his hand outstretched, turning it over, and it's STABLE for the first time today.

His phone buzzes, and he considers picking it up, and eventually does.

A message from Natalie says: "Get some air?"

Carmy looks up, and sees his jacket on the coat hangar.

He thinks about what Natalie said.

Finally, he decides she's right. He GRABS A COAT and LEAVES for the night.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Sydney finishes a line of orders, and stops for a breather. She wipes the sweat of her forehead with her apron.

She does a small lap around the kitchen checking on each station, and stops near Tina and Ebra.

SYDNEY

How we doing over here?

TINA

Never better, chef.

EBRAHEIM

Working my ass off. It's a busy day. I like busy.

SYDNEY

That's what I like to hear.

Sydney makes her way back towards her station.

Before she gets back into the zone, Richie bursts back in.

RICHIE

We're fucked in the ass.

SYDNEY

Language!

RICHIE

Sorry, chef. This guy doesn't like any of the dishes.

SYDNEY

Nothing? I just fired that steak  
he's eating.

RICHIE

Forget the food, we need to do  
more, because I'm losing him out  
there, and I feel like if we don't  
knock his socks off then we're dead  
in the water.

SYDNEY

I'm doing my job, and you do yours,  
isn't that right?

RICHIE

I need you to do more.

SYDNEY

Like what?!

TINA

You could flirt with him?

RICHIE

YES! That's it. I love you, mama!

TINA

Love you too, boo.

SYDNEY

Nuh-uh. We're not doing that here.

RICHIE

You have to.

SYDNEY

Fuck off, Richie.

TINA

Baby, it's not that bad.

SYDNEY

This isn't up for discussion, not  
get back to work!

TINA

Just come here a sec.

Tina grabs her by the arm, and they move to the window.

They look through the window as Jason sits at his table  
looking around absent-mindedly.

TINA (CONT'D)  
You're telling there's an issue  
hitting that?

SYDNEY  
I'm hitting him now?!

TINA  
You can hit on him.

SYDNEY  
I don't know how I feel about that.

Sydney takes another look.

TINA  
C'mon girl, get out there.

SYDNEY  
Fine, I'll talk to him.

She starts walking away.

TINA  
Yeah that's right, you talk to him!

SYDNEY  
(defiant)  
I'm just going to offer him more  
water!

Richie notices Sydney walking towards the kitchen door, and  
shoots Tina a look.

RICHIE  
We in business?

Tina gives a thumbs up and smiles. Richie does an air pump in  
return.

Marcus emerges next to Richie after overhearing the exchange.

MARCUS  
Is Sydney really going out to --

RICHIE  
You bet.

MARCUS  
Don't you think that's a serious  
violation of ethics?

RICHIE  
You can shove the ethics up your  
ass.

MARCUS  
What?  
(calling after Sydney)  
Syd, wait!

RICHIE  
Can it. Get back on dessert.

Sydney walks out before Marcus gets her attention.

Marcus looks furious and shoots daggers at Richie, but he ignores him.

Marcus backs down back into his station.

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA

Sydney nears the critic's table, but tries to psyche herself up first. She tries for charming, but her face tells us she's only half convinced herself.

Sydney walks up timidly to Jason who has a mouth full of the Lemon Chicken dish.

SYDNEY  
(with half a smile)  
Hey, I'm Sydney.

Jason's surprised by the comment, and takes a swig of his drink to get the bite down.

JASON  
Sorry, what was that?

SYDNEY  
Oh, sorry. I- How do you like the food?

JASON  
The chicken is cooked perfectly,  
but I think the sauce might have  
too much acid for my stomach.

SYDNEY  
You know my dad has really loud-  
nevermind. What's your drink of  
choice then?

Jason's not sure how to respond, he looks at his glass of water, then awkwardly raises it.

JASON  
I've been sober since college, to  
be honest with you.

SYDNEY  
Oh, yeah, of course. Me too...

She tries for a laugh, but nothing goes.

Sydney realizes there's nothing there. She SNAPS OUT of it, and decides to stand up for herself.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)  
You know what, I'm doing my best in  
there, and I'm a little confused  
about where you're at. Do you think  
we could just start over or --

Just then, RICHIE COMES OVER.

RICHIE  
How's it going, pal. Listen, why  
don't I clear your table, and we  
can get you the best dish on the  
menu?

JASON  
I wasn't getting your best?

SYDNEY  
Richie, can I handle this?

RICHIE  
(to Jason)  
Well, this is our Sous, and these  
aren't really her dishes, but I can  
tell you what's really good --

JASON  
Hold on, your head chef isn't back  
there?

RICHIE  
That's not what I said.

SYDNEY  
Jason, this guy is not a chef, if  
you would just listen to me --

Before she can take a hold, MARCUS JOINS with a small DESSERT  
IN HAND.

MARCUS  
How's it going, I've got this  
specially-made pastry here for you.

JASON  
Oh thank you, but I didn't order  
that.

SYDNEY  
Marcus, what are you doing?

MARCUS  
Don't worry about that, sir, this  
is just my own thing I wanted you  
to try.

RICHIE  
Get this out of here dude.

Richie PUSHES Marcus' arm away from the table.

MARCUS  
Back off my dish man.

SYDNEY  
I need you guys both to get out of  
here.

MARCUS  
Let me just put this down.

Marcus starts to set the dish down.

SYDNEY  
(stern)  
No! Just go, now.

Richie tries to GRAB the dish, but instead he KNOCKS IT OVER  
and it FALLS ALL OVER JASON.

Jason SHOOTS up from his seat immediately.

JASON  
Shit. Shit.

MARCUS  
I am so sorry --

RICHIE  
Look what ya did --

MARCUS  
That was YOU!

SYDNEY  
Guys, BACK OFF.

JASON  
Can I get some space here?

SYDNEY  
I'm so sorry.

RICHIE  
Let me grab you a wet towel.

Marcus takes his apron off and holds it out to Jason.

MARCUS  
Here, use this.

JASON  
No. GUYS. I need to get to the  
bathroom. Just give me some space.

Everyone backs up immediately.

JASON (CONT'D)  
Thank you.

Jason calmly walks off.

The group turns to each other to get back at it.

SYDNEY  
What is wrong with you two?

RICHIE  
Yeah, what the hell Marcus?

MARCUS  
Are you guys serious? You scared  
him off.

RICHIE  
Here we go again.

SYDNEY  
Both of you, shut it. Kitchen, now.

MARCUS  
Syd, I'm sorry.

SYDNEY  
Save it.

They all turn and head into the kitchen.

Fak turns back to the person he's been waiting after they've left.

FAK  
My... my good sir, please accept my sincerest apologies.

The man gives a wry smile, and continues eating.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

The trio shuffle in embarrassed.

SYDNEY  
I don't even know where to begin with you two.

MARCUS  
Sydney, I know Richie screwed things up, but let me make it up to you.

RICHIE  
He wouldn't be here if it wasn't for me.

SYDNEY  
You're both idiots.

Sweeps makes his way in to check on the situation.

SWEEPS  
Guys, the critic just left, is everything okay?

SYDNEY  
And now he's gone, genius. You both screwed up, and you're both going to fix it.

SWEEPS  
Why am I not surprised?

SYDNEY  
Sweeps, tell Natalie that I need her to take over for Richie.

SWEEPS  
On it, chef.

Sweeps leaves.

SYDNEY

Now you guys are going to salvage  
whatever you can out of this guy  
before he ruins our image. Heard?

RICHIE

Heard.

MARCUS

Heard.

SYDNEY

Get the hell out of here.

RICHIE

What are you going to do?

SYDNEY

If the menu's the problem, I'm  
making my own thing. Besides,  
Carry's not here, so...

Richie rolls his eyes, and Marcus catches it.

MARCUS

C'mon, let's leave.

They head for the exit and pass the office where Sweeps is  
looking for Natalie, but her chair is empty.

SWEEPS

Have you guys seen Natalie?

RICHIE

She left a bit ago.

Sweeps sighs and moves on.

EXT. STREETS OF CHICAGO - MOMENTS LATER

The city is ALIVE.

Braving the winter wind, people wear beanies and jackets.

Carry makes his way down a street. It seems like he's  
searching for something rather than knowing where he's going.

A RESTAURANT SIGN catches his eye. He throws his hoodie up,  
and makes a sharp right.

INT. ROSEBUD - CONTINUOUS

A HOST waits at a small stand near the entrance. Carry walks  
up to them.

CARMY

Do you guys have room for one?

HOST

Absolutely, right this way.

The host leads Carmy up a flight of stairs, and into a dining room.

He's seated at a small booth in the back of the room.

He gets the seat, and is left with a MENU. The cover is adorned with a RED ROSE, and reads: ROSEBUD.

Carmy opens it and examines every recipe like it's a secret to life.

Finally, his waiter comes over.

WAITER

Good evening, can I get you a drink to start?

CARMY

How about the Broccolini to start?

WAITER

Sure, anything else?

CARMY

Any recommendations for dinner?

WAITER

Our salmon is fantastic.

CARMY

I'm good on fish.

WAITER

I'll be back with your appetizer then.

The waiter walks off.

Carmy's left with his own thoughts, but tries to keep himself occupied.

He picks up the SALT SHAKER, CONDIMENTS, NAPKINS - inspecting what brand they are.

A commotion grows louder from across the room at another table, and grabs Carmy's attention.

As it becomes audible, his hand starts to twitch.

CUSTOMER

I asked specifically for sauce on the side, and why are there only four croutons in this side salad? HMM?!

WAITRESS

I'm sorry sir, I can get the kitchen to do this over or --

HEAD CHEF

I should hope that's the least you'll offer me?

WAITRESS

Let me talk to my manager.

The waitress walks off a little shaken.

The scene ends, and Carmy stills his hand. It stabilizes without much trouble.

His waiter comes through the kitchen doors with his food.

WAITER

Sorry about that. Here's your starter.

Carmy thanks him, and picks up his fork.

Before he starts, the customer from before is rude to his waitress once more.

Carmy's hand SHAKES AGAIN, but this time it's persistent.

He waves his waiter back.

WAITER (CONT'D)

Yes, sir?

CARMY

Could I just get a small shot of vodka or whatever?

The waiter nods, and leaves. Carmy grabs his hand STIFF, closing his eyes to stop feeling its effect.

Once again, he's alone at his table, but this time he notices some new guests be seated. At his original table across the room, CLAIRE and a few friends sit down.

Carmy's HEART DROPS.

He begins to panic internally, and his hand starts going again.

He fiddles around to try and obscure his image, but he can't help taking a glance at her table.

He sees her laughing with her friends, and having a good time.

He MISSES the feeling, STARES a little too long and...

Claire turns - their eyes MEET, but only for a moment.

Carmy turns his face.

HAND SHAKING.

KNUCKLES WHITE.

He throws down two twenty dollar bills, and leaves immediately.

EXT. STREETS OF CHICAGO - MOMENTS LATER

Carmy makes his way as far from the restaurant as possible.

Every few strides, he turns back expecting to see Claire, but he turns the corner alone.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Fak walks into for a small breather.

Sydney is LOCKED IN making a large dish.

FAK

Whew, I've been with that guy all day. He just keeps ordering, says he loves the food.

SYDNEY

(uninterested)

That's great Fak.

FAK

Whatchya guys doin' in here?

SYDNEY

What's it look like?

FAK  
Sheesh, sorry, just checking in  
after you guys blew it with the  
critic.

SYDNEY  
I didn't blow anything, Marcus and  
Richie blew it. I'm fixing it.

FAK  
Oh okay, I can get behind that!  
Well, if you get a second, you  
should really meet this guy, I  
think he --

SYDNEY  
Busy right now.

Fak gets the message and walks away.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)  
Fak, grab Natalie for me!

Sydney puts her KNIFE DOWN and takes a deep breath.  
She heads over to the OVENS to check on something.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)  
(walking)  
CORNER!

She gets there and takes a dish out, laying it on the counter  
behind. She closes the oven, and Natalie appears next to her.

NATALIE  
Hey, what's up?

SYDNEY  
Any update on Richie and Marcus?

NATALIE  
Let me get one for you.

Natalie steps away, and places a call to --

EXT. BIG APPLE MEDIA - SAME TIME

Richie picks up his phone to answer Natalie.

RICHIE  
What's good?

NATALIE

You tell me, talked to the critic yet?

RICHIE

We're walking in right now.

NATALIE

Don't screw this up, Sydney is counting on you guys.

MARCUS

I got him covered, Nat.

RICHIE

Shut up.

(to Natalie)

I'll handle it.

He hangs up.

RICHIE (CONT'D)

We gotta fix this or else we're in deep shit.

MARCUS

We? This is on you. I'm here for Sydney.

RICHIE

Whatever. Just, when we get in there, let me do the talking.

MARCUS

We're here to talk about food, I'm the chef.

RICHIE

Yeah, and I'm the guy who knows how to take care of people.

MARCUS

You don't know what you're talking about.

RICHIE

Follow my lead.

MARCUS

I'm going to do what Sydney would want us to do.

They ignore each other, but walk in anyway.

INT. GRIDDLE DINER - LATER

Carmy walks in and settles into a stool at the corner of the bar. A waitress welcomes him.

WAITRESS  
Hey hon, what can I get you?

CARMY  
Decaf.

She holds out a menu.

CARMY (CONT'D)  
No thanks.

The waitress walks away.

He watches the cooks behind the bar do their magic. It's nothing fancy, but it's easier to stomach than the other place.

MICKY, an older cook, KNOCKS OVER a CASE OF MUSHROOMS. They land somewhere near Carmy's feet, and on instinct, he helps clean them up.

MICKY  
Nice reflexes.

CARMY  
I make a living out of it.

MICKY  
(laughs)  
You wanna give me a hand with these eggs too? My son couldn't come in today.

Carmy takes a look at the stove, and then at his hand. He seems fine, and leans into it.

CARMY  
I'll give it a shot.

He walks up to the station, and throws BUTTER into a PAN.

It MELTS SOFTLY.

MICKY  
I need two eggs scrambled, and three fried.

CARMY  
Heard, chef.

MICKY  
Call me Micky.

Carmy smiles, and grabs TWO EGGS.

CARMY  
Coming right up, Micky.

CRACK! In. CRACK! In.

He WHISKS the YOLK and MOVES the PAN at the same time. All with his RIGHT HAND - steady as a rock.

INT. BIG APPLE MEDIA - MOMENTS LATER

They scan a sea of desks, and finally spot Jason sitting at one.

RICHIE  
There. He's got a miniature Statue of Liberty on his desk, can you believe this guy?

MARCUS  
Does he have any workout equipment there?

RICHIE  
What? Why would he have that at his desk?

MARCUS  
Don't worry about it.

Marcus' brow furrows, and Richie puts on his nicest face, and they approach Jason.

RICHIE  
Hey, how about that, would never have thought to see you here?

JASON  
(suspicious)  
What's going on guys?

RICHIE  
Listen, I know you know we didn't really bump into you here as a coincidence, we came here to apologize.

JASON  
Alright.

RICHIE  
So, yeah, we just didn't feel good  
about how your meal went and I  
wanted to know if you'd be  
interested in - let's say a second  
round?

JASON  
I'm not quite sure I follow.

RICHIE  
What I mean is-

DING!

Jason's phone LIGHTS UP on his desk.

JASON  
Hold on.

Jason picks his phone up.

MARCUS  
What's that?

JASON  
Huh?

MARCUS  
You texting someone?

JASON  
It's none of your business.

Marcus sighs, frustrated.

RICHIE  
Anyway, I was saying we're hoping  
you'll come back, and we can give  
you the best service you've ever  
had. And, maybe, just maybe, if you  
enjoy yourself enough you'll change  
your review. I think that sounds  
plausible, right?

JASON  
Let me stop you right there, that's  
not how I work guys.

DING!

The phone lights up again, this time Marcus sees the contact  
name: SYDNEY.

Without thinking, he GRABS JASON'S PHONE!

JASON (CONT'D)  
What the hell!

MARCUS  
This guy's texting Sydney. You're  
messing with our staff!

JASON  
Give me my phone back!

RICHIE  
Dude, drop the phone.

MARCUS  
Not until you tell me exactly what  
you're doing with her?

JASON  
Doing with my sister? Fuck off!

MARCUS  
Who?

RICHIE  
Give him his phone!

Richie grabs the phone out of Marcus' hands and returns it to  
Jason.

JASON  
You guys are fucking insane!

RICHIE  
Sorry man.

JASON  
GET OUT!

RICHIE  
Yeah, we're going.  
(to Marcus)  
C'mon.

Richie turns Marcus away and they walk out.

INT. SYDNEY'S CAR - MOMENTS LATER

Sydney drives, a tray of food joins her in the passenger  
seat.

She gets a call and answers.

SYDNEY  
This better be good news.

RICHIE (O.S.)  
It's not.

SYDNEY  
(sighs)  
What happened?!

RICHIE (O.S.)  
I- I don't know, that guys a dick,  
and-

He looks at Marcus, debating whether to rat him out.

RICHIE (O.S.) (CONT'D)  
It just didn't work out. We might  
need your help.

SYDNEY  
Gimme a few, I'm close by. Don't  
make this worse before I get there!

She hangs up.

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA

Fak is now seated opposite the man he was serving earlier.  
They're both laughing hysterically.

FAK  
So we were all kind of freaking  
out. The last thing we needed was  
to fail another class. We snuck  
into our teacher's office - while  
she was there - and we looked for  
our exams. It's dead quiet, we  
didn't want to get caught, but I  
had kind of a bad lunch, and I  
couldn't help but fart.

They both explode with laughter.

FAK (CONT'D)  
Yeah, I flunked that class, and  
dropped out the next year.  
(notices empty glass)  
Let me get you another round.

Fak gets up, and heads into the--

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA - CONTINUOUS

Fak finds Natalie walking around.

FAK

Hey, this guys is awesome. Turns out he can do real business for us, you need to get Sydney on the phone.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS BEFORE

Carmy walks to his coffee table, and sets down a WHITE PIN. In black letters it reads: GRIDDLE DINER.

KNOCK KNOCK.

Carmy turns and makes his way to the--

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/DOORWAY - CONTINUOUS

He eyes the peephole, and comes away surprised.

He opens up all the locks to reveal Sydney.

SYDNEY

I come bearing food.

CARMY

That's a lot for one guy.

SYDNEY

(tired)

Can I put this down inside?

CARMY

Yeah, come in.

He lets her in and closes the door. They move into the--

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Sydney sets the dish down on his stove.

CARMY

Listen, today was--

SYDNEY

Nope. No talking. Try this first.

She peels back the foil, and makes him a spoon.

Carmy tries it.

CARMY  
It's great. What is it exactly?

SYDNEY  
It's my own thing.

CARMY  
We should put it on the menu,  
you're right.

SYDNEY  
That's not what I'm saying. I can  
make my own food, but The Bear is  
your place. They're your dishes,  
and your customers. You need to be  
there.

CARMY  
I wasn't there opening night, and  
people liked the food all the same.

SYDNEY  
That's not it. We're all making  
this work, because of you. But,  
without you, this doesn't exist. No  
more excuses.

Carmy takes a deep breath.

CARMY  
You're right. I was dealing with  
something today, but I think I  
figured it out. It's not about the  
food, it's about the people. I'm  
sorry I let you guys down.

SYDNEY  
Don't be sorry, come into work.

CARMY  
Heard.

Carmy offers a hand, and Sydney laughs, but she shakes it and  
they resolve the tension.

Sydney's phone rings, and she picks up.

SYDNEY  
Yo.

NATALIE (O.S.)  
Fak has something big.

SYDNEY  
I got Carmy.

NATALIE (O.S.)  
Perfect, come back.

SYDNEY  
On our way.

She hangs up.

CARMY  
Did I just hear that Fak has  
something big?

SYDNEY  
It's been a weird day. Let's go?

CARMY  
Yeah. Wait, what happened with the  
critic?

SYDNEY  
Shit.

EXT. BIG APPLE MEDIA - SAME TIME

Richie and Marcus sit on the steps of the office campus when  
Richie gets a text from Sydney.

He picks it up and reads: "Fuck the critic".

RICHIE  
Finally.

Marcus looks up, and Richie shows him the text.

MARCUS  
Should we get out of here?

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA - LATER

Fak escorts his faithful customer out for the night.

FAK  
You have a wonderful evening, good  
sir. We look forward to your  
return.

He waves and closes the door.

FAK (CONT'D)  
Woohooo! That was my best  
performance!

Eager to gloat, he heads into the--

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA - CONTINUOUS

The crew is cleaning up as Fak's customer was the last of the day.

He finds Natalie, who walks in from the back with Sydney and Carmy.

CARMY  
What'd I miss?

FAK  
You're back! You won't believe  
this. I just spent the entire day  
with the regional manager of Uber  
Eats!

SYDNEY  
You're kidding?

FAK  
Not even a little. He had such a  
good time, he said he's catering  
his meetings from here every week.

NATALIE  
Oh my god, that's incredible.

CARMY  
Fak, buddy, you saved us.

FAK  
I totally did!

They all pat him on the back.

Richie and Marcus walk in after their excursion.

MARCUS  
Sorry, we're late.

RICHIE  
Had to take care of some things.

NATALIE  
What'd you do?

RICHIE  
Don't worry about it.

NATALIE  
I feel like I should worry about  
it.

CARMY  
Forget it, they're just some idiot  
bloggers. We got the real judges  
right here. All that matters is the  
people that eat here. We take care  
of this city, I'm not worried about  
New York fine dining anymore, this  
is all about second city fine  
dining.

RICHIE  
That's something I can get with.

They give each other a nod, and everyone agrees.

Marcus takes Sydney aside.

MARCUS  
Syd, I screwed up. I just want you  
to know it won't happen again.

SYDNEY  
I gotta be able to count on you  
when it's tough out here, you're  
one of the best I got. Sometimes I  
feel like I'm running this thing  
alone and-

MARCUS  
You're not. I got your back.

SYDNEY  
Promise?

MARCUS  
Promise.

They tie pinkies.

CARMY  
So who's on cleaning duty tonight?

He looks around to blank stares.

CARMY (CONT'D)  
I'm kidding. I got it.

NATALIE

You bet your ass. I'm going to bed.

RICHIE

Same. See ya.

Everyone starts to leave.

Carmy looks around at the mess, and grabs a nearby broom.

A few sweeps go by, and Sydney brings another broom right next to him.

They exchange a look of teamwork, but sweep away without saying anything.

Fak gets to the door, before giving in, and jogging back to help.

FAK

I just can't help it. You guys are the best. I don't know what I'd do without you guys. I mean I pulled it off today. Can you believe I handed all that. I mean it was like...

His voice fades as continues to Fak ramble, and something like "THE MIDDLE" By JIMMY EAT WORLD takes us out.

FADE TO BLACK:

CREDITS.

The End.